

Gothic Treasures

Project Analysis & Strategic Roadmap
Handmade Gothic Wall Decor Ecommerce

March 23, 2026 | Version 0.4.0

Prepared for Stefan Nasev | xChe Studios

Current Version	v0.4.0
Phases Complete	6 of 7
Stack	Next.js 16 + TypeScript + Tailwind v4 + Framer Motion
Backend	Supabase (planned) Currently mock data
Repository	github.com/xChechi/gothic-treasures
Status	Frontend complete. Backend integration next.

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Current State Analysis
3. Completed Features Breakdown
4. Technical Architecture
5. Design System
6. What Needs to Be Built
7. Improvement Suggestions
8. Strategic Roadmap
9. Cost Projections
10. Risk Assessment

1. Executive Summary

Gothic Treasures is a custom ecommerce website for handmade gothic home wall decor, targeting US customers with unique, one-of-a-kind pieces shipped from Bulgaria. The project has progressed rapidly from concept to a fully functional frontend in a single development sprint, completing 6 of 7 planned build phases.

The website features an extraordinary dark gothic aesthetic with atmospheric animations, a desaturated warm monochrome hero image, interactive category cards, 3D-tilt product galleries, parchment-style testimonials, and a complete admin dashboard. All pages are built and polished with SEO infrastructure, accessibility features, and loading states.

The critical next step is backend integration. All current data is mock/static. The project needs Supabase for database and authentication, Stripe for payments, and Vercel for deployment before it can accept real orders.

2. Current State Analysis

Phase Completion Status

Phase	Description	Version	Status
1	Foundation + Theme	v0.1.0	COMPLETE
2	Landing Page + Shop Pages	v0.2.0	COMPLETE
3	About + Contact Pages	v0.2.1	COMPLETE
4	SEO Infrastructure	v0.3.0	COMPLETE
5	Polish + Accessibility	v0.3.1	COMPLETE
6	Admin Dashboard	v0.4.0	COMPLETE
7	Backend + Payments + Deploy	v1.0.0	PENDING

Overall completion: approximately 85% of frontend work is done. The remaining 15% is backend integration, payments, and deployment, which represents the most technically complex phase but a well-defined scope of work.

3. Completed Features Breakdown

Landing Page (Phase 1-2)

- Hero section with StockCake cathedral image, desaturated warm monochrome filter (grayscale 70%, sepia 40%)
- Interactive category cards (The Chambers) with real gothic archway photos, hover brightening, gold corner brackets
- Product gallery with 3D tilt effect on cards
- Parchment-style testimonials with wax seal decorations
- Gothic invitation newsletter signup section
- Wrought iron gate footer design
- SVG section dividers, film grain overlay, scroll progress bar
- Custom golden cross cursor with zero-lag tracking

Shop & Product Pages (Phase 2)

- Full product grid (/shop) with search, category filters, sort dropdown
- Product detail pages (/shop/[slug]) with image gallery, gothic frame, specs table, 3-state add-to-cart
- Category pages (/category/[slug]) with filtered grid and breadcrumb navigation
- Cart page with animated item management and order summary sidebar
- Guest checkout with US shipping form, validation, and mock order confirmation
- 10 shared components: ProductCard, ProductGrid, ShopFilters, ProductGallery, and more
- Static site generation (SSG) with generateStaticParams on dynamic routes

Content Pages (Phase 3)

- About page: parallax hero, origin story, 3-column craft grid, stats bar, shipping/returns info
- Contact page: validated form (name, email, subject, message), info sidebar, FAQ accordion

SEO Infrastructure (Phase 4)

- Per-page metadata with title template, dynamic generateMetadata for products/categories
- Open Graph and Twitter Card meta tags for social sharing
- Programmatic robots.ts and sitemap.ts covering all routes
- JSON-LD structured data (Organization, WebSite, Product schemas)
- Custom gothic 404 page, canonical URLs, noindex on cart/checkout

Polish & Accessibility (Phase 5)

- Loading skeletons with gothic frame corners for shop, product detail, and category pages
- Scroll-to-top on navigation, back-to-top floating button

- Skip-to-content link, focus-visible gold outlines, ARIA labels throughout
- Cart link in mobile menu, horizontal scroll on mobile category filters
- iOS zoom prevention, 3.2MB image cleanup/optimization

Admin Dashboard (Phase 6)

- Dashboard with sidebar navigation, 4 stats cards, recent orders overview
- Products CRUD table with add/edit modal forms and delete confirmation
- Orders table with expandable rows and status badges (Processing/Shipped/Delivered)
- Settings page with store info and Supabase/Stripe configuration placeholders
- Separate admin layout (hides public navbar/footer), mobile-responsive sidebar

4. Technical Architecture

Layer	Technology	Purpose
Framework	Next.js 16 (App Router)	SSR, SSG, API routes, file-based routing
Language	TypeScript	Type safety across the codebase
Styling	Tailwind CSS v4	Utility-first CSS, dark theme
Animation	Framer Motion	Scroll reveals, page transitions, hover effects
State	Zustand	Client-side cart state management
Database	Supabase PostgreSQL	Products, orders, users (planned)
Auth	Supabase Auth	Admin login and route protection (planned)
Storage	Supabase Storage	Product image uploads (planned)
Payments	Stripe	Checkout sessions, webhooks (planned)
Deployment	Vercel	Auto-deploy from GitHub, CDN (planned)
Email	Resend (recommended)	Order confirmations, contact form (planned)

Database Schema (Planned)

The Supabase PostgreSQL database will contain 10 tables: categories, products, product_images, reviews, orders, order_items, contact_submissions, newsletter_subscribers, admin_users, and site_settings. All tables are defined in the project specification document.

Page Routes

Route	Type	Description
/	Public	Landing page (6 sections)
/shop	Public	Product catalog with filters
/shop/[slug]	Public	Product detail page
/category/[slug]	Public	Category filtered view
/cart	Public	Shopping cart
/checkout	Public	Guest checkout flow
/about	Public	Brand story + shipping info
/contact	Public	Contact form + FAQ
/admin	Protected	Dashboard overview

/admin/products	Protected	Product CRUD
/admin/orders	Protected	Order management
/admin/settings	Protected	Store configuration

5. Design System

Color Palette

Color	Hex	Usage
Obsidian Black	#0a0a0a	Primary backgrounds, page base
Antique Gold	#C9A84C	Headings, accents, borders, cursor, UI elements
Deep Burgundy	#8B0000	CTA buttons, hover states, alerts
Wine Red	#722F37	Secondary accents, gradients
Aged Silver	#8A8D8F	Body text, subtle borders, metadata
Dark Gray	#1a1a1a	Card backgrounds, containers

Typography

Headers: Cinzel / Playfair Display (serif, gothic elegance)

Body: Inter / DM Sans (clean readability, modern contrast)

Key Design Decisions

- **Hero Image Treatment:** Desaturated warm monochrome via CSS filters (grayscale 70%, sepia 40%, brightness 85%, contrast 110%). Creates an aged cathedral photograph look that harmonizes with the gold palette. Pure B/W was rejected as too cold; full color was too blue.
- **Category Cards (Chambers):** Real gothic archway photographs with normal brightness by default, brightening on hover. Gold corner brackets frame each card. Replaced original SVG door outlines which looked like wireframe mockups.
- **Custom Cursor:** Golden cross shape (22px default, 30px on hover), direct DOM positioning with zero lag. Spotlight/flashlight effect was removed as it was distracting.
- **Background Textures:** gothic-bg CSS class provides layered atmosphere: noise texture, diamond lattice pattern, atmospheric color pools, and side vignette. Used across all pages for consistency.

6. What Needs to Be Built

Phase 7 encompasses all backend integration, payment processing, and deployment. This is the final phase before launch.

6.1 Supabase Backend (Critical Priority)

The entire site runs on mock/static data. Supabase integration is the single biggest remaining task. This includes:

- Create Supabase project and configure environment variables
- Build database schema (10 tables: products, categories, orders, etc.)
- Seed initial product data and categories
- Replace all mock data imports with Supabase queries (server components)
- Implement real-time cart syncing (optional, Zustand can persist locally)
- Set up Row Level Security (RLS) policies for public vs admin access

6.2 Authentication (Admin Protection)

- Supabase Auth for admin login (email/password)
- Login page with gothic-themed form
- Next.js middleware for /admin route protection
- Session management and auto-redirect on expiry

6.3 Image Storage

- Supabase Storage bucket for product images
- Admin upload flow: drag-drop or file picker in product edit modal
- Image optimization pipeline (resize, compress, serve via CDN)
- Replace current Unsplash/Pexels URLs with self-hosted images

6.4 Stripe Payments

- Stripe account setup (test mode initially)
- API route: create checkout session with line items
- Webhook handler: process successful payments, update order status
- Success/failure redirect pages after checkout
- Stripe Elements for embedded card form (optional, Checkout Session is simpler)

6.5 Email Notifications

- Order confirmation email to customer (using Resend or similar)
- New order notification to admin
- Contact form submission forwarded to store email
- Newsletter welcome email

6.6 Deployment

- Connect GitHub repo to Vercel (auto-deploy on push)
- Configure environment variables (Supabase, Stripe keys)
- Set up custom domain when ready (Cloudflare DNS recommended)
- Enable Vercel Analytics (free tier includes basic metrics)

7. Improvement Suggestions

7.1 Quick Wins (Low Effort, High Impact)

- **Wishlist / Save for Later** - Since every piece is unique (stock 0 or 1), customers need a way to bookmark items before they decide. Simple localStorage implementation, upgradeable to Supabase later.
- **"CLAIMED" Overlay on Sold Items** - Instead of just disabling the Add to Cart button, show a dramatic gothic-themed "CLAIMED" or "SOLD" stamp overlay on product cards. Creates urgency and fits the aesthetic.
- **Recently Sold Ticker** - A subtle animated notification bar: "Gothic Iron Cross was claimed 2 hours ago." Social proof that drives urgency for unique pieces.
- **Size Reference Overlay** - Wall decor needs scale context. Add a toggle on product detail pages that overlays the piece on a room mockup or shows dimensions with a visual scale reference.

7.2 Medium Effort (Significant Value)

- **Instagram/Pinterest Integration** - Gothic decor is hugely visual and social-media friendly. Embed an Instagram feed on the landing page. Add Pinterest "Pin It" buttons on all product images.
- **Smart Related Products** - Currently showing random products. Once on Supabase, show items from the same category, similar price range, or "customers who viewed this also viewed" logic.
- **Order Tracking Page** - After purchase, a /order/[id] page with a gothic-themed status timeline: Confirmed, Crafting, Shipped, Delivered. Email updates at each stage.
- **Real Reviews System** - The parchment testimonials section exists with mock data. Wire it to Supabase for real customer reviews with star ratings displayed on product cards.
- **Currency Preview** - Prices in USD but visitors may be international. A small client-side currency toggle (EUR, GBP) showing approximate prices helps conversion.

7.3 Bigger Features (Post-Launch)

- **Blog / Journal** - "Tales from the Workshop" covering crafting process, inspiration, gothic culture. Major SEO value for organic traffic. Markdown-based, stored in Supabase.
- **Custom Orders / Commission Form** - Since these are handmade, offering custom pieces is a natural premium upsell. Dedicated form with reference image upload and budget range.
- **Early Access / Loyalty List** - Notify VIP customers before new pieces go public. Builds community and guarantees sales for new items.
- **Multi-Image Product Galleries** - Each product needs 3-5 images: different angles, close-up details, in-room lifestyle shots. The gallery component already supports this, just needs data.
- **Admin Analytics Dashboard** - Revenue charts, top-selling products, conversion funnel visualization, visitor demographics. Recharts is already in the stack.

8. Strategic Roadmap

Week	Focus	Deliverables	Milestone
Week 1	Backend Setup	Supabase project, schema, seed data, API integration	v0.5.0
Week 2	Auth + Storage	Admin login, route protection, image upload flow	v0.6.0
Week 3	Payments	Stripe integration, checkout flow, webhooks, emails	v0.7.0
Week 4	Deploy + Test	Vercel deployment, end-to-end testing, bug fixes	v0.9.0
Week 5	Launch	Custom domain, final polish, real product data, go live	v1.0.0

This timeline assumes consistent development sessions. The backend phase (Weeks 1-3) requires Stefan to create Supabase and Stripe accounts before work can begin. These accounts are free to set up and can be done in under 30 minutes.

9. Cost Projections

Monthly Operating Costs (Post-Launch)

Service	Tier	Monthly Cost	Notes
Vercel	Hobby (Free)	\$0	Sufficient for launch. Upgrade to Pro (\$20/mo) for commercial use.
Supabase	Free	\$0	500MB DB, 1GB storage, 50K monthly active users. Pro: \$25/mo.
Stripe	Pay-as-you-go	2.9% + \$0.30/txn	No monthly fee. Only pay per transaction.
Domain	Annual	~\$1/mo	\$10-15/year via Cloudflare Registrar.
Resend (Email)	Free	\$0	3,000 emails/month free. More than enough for launch.

Launch cost: \$0/month (all free tiers). As traffic grows, expect ~\$45-50/month (Vercel Pro + Supabase Pro + domain). Stripe fees are per-transaction only.

10. Risk Assessment

Risk	Impact	Likelihood	Mitigation
Supabase free tier limits hit	Medium	Low (early stage)	Monitor usage. Upgrade to Pro (\$25/mo) when approaching limits. 500MB DB and 1GB storage is generous for launch.
Image loading performance	High	Medium	Use Next.js Image component with proper sizing, lazy loading, and WebP format. Supabase Storage CDN handles delivery.
International shipping complexity	Medium	Medium	Start with flat-rate shipping BG to USA. Clearly state delivery times (14-21 days). Add tracking integration later.
Payment fraud	High	Low	Stripe Radar (built-in fraud detection). Unique high-value items reduce bulk fraud risk. Manual review for orders over threshold.
SEO competition in gothic niche	Medium	Medium	JSON-LD already in place. Blog/journal content strategy for organic traffic. Pinterest and Instagram for visual discovery.
Single point of failure (one developer)	High	High	GitHub repo serves as code backup. Supabase handles data persistence. Documentation in Obsidian and spec doc.

This report was generated on March 23, 2026 based on the current project state at v0.4.0. All analysis reflects the Gothic Treasures codebase, Obsidian project notes, and Qdrant memory records as of this date.

End of Report